

Chapter 35 Part 4

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Xu Qingzhu went unimpeded all the way to the CEO's office.

In the office, Xu Guangyao was brewing a pot of tea while looking over marketing proposals submitted by the marketing department. Seeing that it was Xu Qingzhu who entered, he just frowned slightly before lowering his head to look at documents again.

Xu Qingzhu didn't react much either. The lunch break was short, so she walked to the desk and asked directly: "Do you know who Zhou Yi'an is?"

Xu Guangyao looked up at his daughter, who had already become adept at navigating the workplace despite just entering it, and answered: "I know."

"Dad." Xu Qingzhu called to him. "I know what you're thinking. Now all the celebrities in the circle want to curry favor with Mr. Zhou, so Zhou Yi'an has become the target of everyone's flattery. But even if a pie falls from heaven, don't you check what filling it has? Not every pie can be eaten."

Xu Guangyao poured her a cup of tea, his tone gentle and calm: "Sit."

Xu Qingzhu sat across from him. She didn't drink the tea, just continued: "Dad, haven't you thought about why Zhou Yi'an wants to come to Minghui? With her status and qualifications, there are plenty of big companies that want her. Why would she come to Minghui?!"

"That would have to be asked of Zhou Yi'an." Xu Guangyao suddenly frowned. "Did you just come here to interrogate me?"

Xu Qingzhu took a deep breath: "No, I just came to ask you why you recruited Zhou Yi'an. Our temple is small¹ and can't accommodate such a big Buddha."

"If we can accommodate even you, how can we not accommodate her?" Xu Guangyao said. "It was just that I encountered Miss Zhou by chance at the banquet that day and learned that Miss Zhou was a top student from a prestigious foreign university's design department. She had just returned to the country not long ago and wanted to find a jewelry company for internship. Her understanding was still of the Minghui Jewelry from many years ago. What's wrong with wanting to work at Minghui?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She first ignored her father's earlier sarcastic words about her, focusing only on his latter statement: "Dad, as the daughter of the Zhou family, and having worked in this industry for several years, how could she not know Minghui's current situation? Why can you be so naïve..."

Halfway through her words, Xu Guangyao's expression had already changed.

Xu Qingzhu picked up the water cup and drank the tea in one gulp, swallowing all her words back.

That word "naive" ultimately wasn't spoken.

Only after calming down did she continue: "Did Zhou Yi'an approach you proactively?"

"Yes." Xu Guangyao said. "We met by chance at the banquet. She said she hadn't found work yet, so I extended an olive branch to her. RT's annual emerging designer - just this title alone is enough. If our autumn new product launch has her work, won't we be able to make a sensation?"

At this point, Xu Guangyao's eyes and brows were tinged with smugness. "Those two people you brought in - I looked at their work. Isn't it all just superficial? Young people nowadays won't like it."

"Who says so?" Xu Qingzhu said. "Those are clearly very innovative designs. I don't care - the flagship item for the autumn collection must be Lin Luoxi's work. I swallowed my pride to ask her to come, and she stayed up all night rushing to complete so many drafts. If you want to replace her work at this critical moment, then I..."

The words "won't do it anymore" got stuck in her throat.

She couldn't say them no matter what.

She couldn't possibly not do it.

Once she stopped, it would push Minghui into the abyss, and it would go bankrupt sooner or later.

But Xu Guangyao picked up on her unfinished words: "Won't do it anymore, right? Then resign. Regardless of how Lin Luoxi's design is, as long as we use Miss Zhou's reputation, there will definitely be media and celebrities buying it. Our marketing will definitely occupy an advantageous position. Plus those socialites - to curry favor with Mr. Zhou, they'll have to give our products some face. For this autumn collection, the flagship item must be Miss Zhou's design."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She knew this was what her father was planning!

Short-sighted!

During her time at the company, she had roughly figured out why the company was gradually declining.

Nepotism - most of the company's employees had some kind of family connections. Take the design department manager, for example. He was some shareholder's nephew who couldn't find work after graduation, so he was arranged into Minghui Jewelry's marketing department. Later, when Qin Sisi resigned, this incompetent guy was directly transferred to the design department.

Other departments had this phenomenon to some extent as well.

Xu Qingzhu wanted to carry out sweeping reforms, but now she had to focus on the autumn new product launch first. Only if this went well could she have a voice in the company and save Minghui Jewelry's reputation.

Moreover, Xu Guangyao focused too much on marketing, probably related to the regrets left from when he was a designer.

Originally, as a designer, he thought his work was good but never got opportunities. Those who got opportunities were all works that used high concepts and good marketing. So after becoming chairman of Minghui Jewelry, he had always focused on marketing. He firmly believed that good marketing was like a pig standing at the wind outlet² - no matter how heavy, it could still fly.

After all these years, even though Minghui Jewelry declined year by year, he still firmly believed his theory was correct.

"Dad, I've told you before - for all companies that produce content, content is king." Xu Qingzhu said. "We do need marketing to let the public know about our products, but back then our marketing was already sufficient. Almost everyone knew Minghui. For new companies, marketing is very important, but for established jewelry companies like us, content is the way. Only by ensuring our product styles and quality don't decline can we maintain old customers and have good reputation, which will naturally attract new customers. But you're putting the cart before the horse now!"

"Are you teaching me how to do business?" Xu Guangyao asked in a deep voice.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together and said nothing.

The atmosphere between father and daughter became tense for a moment.

Xu Qingzhu stubbornly held her ground, refusing to give in no matter what.

After a long while, Xu Guangyao was the first to break the silence: "Qingzhu, everything Dad does is for the good of this family. Your health has never been good, and working so hard at the company will exhaust your body.

"I heard from Zhang Qiyi that you worked overtime for five consecutive days last week. How can your body handle this if it continues? Dad doesn't want you to come to the company because he doesn't want you to worry. Why do you have to oppose me? You've already married into the Liang family anyway. Dad will solve all the problems. Just don't ask the Liang family for money anymore. Get along well with Liang Shi - she loves you so much, she won't let you suffer."

Zhang Qiyi was their design department manager.

"If I don't come in, Minghui will go bankrupt and liquidate!" Xu Qingzhu suddenly shouted.

Despite all the hardship and exhaustion these days, she hadn't said a single word of complaint. She just wanted to do everything possible to preserve her grandfather's legacy business.

But what about her father?

Her father wanted her to mind her own business.

And he wanted to rely on someone with an unpredictable temperament.

She clearly wanted to help, but it had turned into opposition.

All the grievances accumulated over these days exploded in an instant. Her shouting stunned Xu Guangyao, but after a moment he replied: "I've been running this for so many years, and Minghui hasn't gone bankrupt! I've still maintained the family well. You went to a private school, and I never let you suffer any grievances."

"But four months ago, if it weren't for the money Liang Shi brought, Minghui would have already gone bankrupt." Xu Qingzhu said. "Even the villa we live in would have had to be mortgaged to the bank."

"That was money Liang Shi gave voluntarily!" Xu Guangyao still refused to admit that it was his management mistakes that led Minghui to such a predicament.

"But why did Liang Shi give it? Can't you use your brain? Or are you just weaving illusions for yourself - as long as Minghui hasn't collapsed yet, you can still live in your utopia!" Xu Qingzhu suppressed her choking voice. "This matter is the same. Why Zhou Yi'an came - don't you really know? She came because of me! To oppose me! Last time at the banquet, I slapped her, so she's coming to cause trouble for me. Now that I've said this, do you understand? Or are you planning to continue pretending not to understand, continue making decisions with your eyes closed, regardless of Minghui's fate?"

Xu Guangyao was made to feel almost ashamed by her words, but still maintained his last shred of dignity, picking apart her words to ask: "Why did you slap her?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She suddenly felt that everything she had just said was like playing music to a cow.³

In her father's eyes, there were only two types of people: those who could be used, and those who couldn't.

Zhou Yi'an was someone who could be used.

He wouldn't think about this being a knife that could stab back at any time.

To him, this was the last straw to grasp.

"Dad." Xu Qingzhu sighed. "There's no point in discussing this now. I just want to ask you - everything in the design department is for me to decide, right?"

"Make Miss Zhou's work the flagship item." Xu Guangyao said.

Xu Qingzhu: "...I absolutely will not compromise on this matter."

Xu Qingzhu knew she couldn't persuade him, so she simply switched to a tough approach: "I also absolutely will not leave Minghui. No matter how tired I get, I will protect this family business."

"You could live a good leisurely life, why do you insist on pushing yourself like this?" Xu Guangyao was annoyed. "Is Liang Shi not treating you well? I'll go find her! She promised to treat my daughter well when you got married! How long has it been since the wedding and she's already changed!"

"It has nothing to do with Liang Shi." Xu Qingzhu stopped him, taking a deep breath. "Dad, I've studied for so many years. I can't just stay home being a full-time housewife. I need to work."

"Then find yourself an easy job. Let Liang Shi arrange something for you at their family company. You don't need to worry about Minghui's affairs." Xu Guangyao said. "I'll handle it."

"But your way of handling it is just procrastination." Xu Qingzhu said. "Delaying day by day until Minghui goes bankrupt and liquidates. This company can't withstand your kind of turmoil."

Xu Guangyao: "..."

Xu Qingzhu said in a deep voice: "I don't need to rely on anyone to get opportunities, and I don't need easy work. If you really care about me, don't stop me from doing these things. Regarding Zhou Yi'an, don't make any deals with her behind my back. That will only make me more passive and make things harder for me."

Footnotes:

1. **"Our temple is small" (咱們家廟小):** A Chinese idiom meaning the organization/place is too small to accommodate someone of high status or ability.
2. **"A pig standing at the wind outlet" (站在風口上的豬):** A popular Chinese business metaphor meaning that with the right timing and favorable conditions, even the most unlikely ventures can succeed.
3. **"Playing music to a cow" (對牛彈琴):** A Chinese idiom meaning to speak to someone who cannot understand or appreciate what you're saying.